Robotics Team Mentorship Program Policy & Program Overview

Purpose. NSF provides student-centered educational mentorship to developing robotics teams. Mentors guide students toward independent design, building, programming, testing, documentation, teamwork, and competition preparation. This is educational support, not a guarantee of placements, funding, awards, or team affiliation.

1 Program scope and eligibility

The program is intended for independent youth robotics teams requesting specific learning support. Applicants may participate in VEX or another suitable robotics program, subject to mentor expertise, available capacity, safety arrangements, and Board-approved scope. A request does not guarantee acceptance. Mentorship does not transfer the team's registration, money, accounts, property, students, or governance to NSF.

2 Application, review, and approval

A team's designated Primary Coach or responsible adult submits the Team Mentorship Intake Form. NSF reviews educational goals, team experience, requested help, schedule, adult supervision, venue suitability, available mentors, and resources. An authorized NSF Program Lead records an approval, proposed modification, request for clarification, or decision not to proceed under the authority actually delegated by the Board.

Following approval, the adult leads complete an Initial Mentorship Plan stating objectives, location, frequency, term, contacts, and review points. Both adult leads confirm the plan before future sessions begin. Intake approval and plan confirmation are separate steps; no volunteer may commit NSF funds or execute a contract without the appropriate authority.

3 Mentorship approach and boundaries

NSF mentors may teach general concepts, demonstrate techniques, ask diagnostic questions, review student-created work, and guide practice. Students remain responsible for their own competition designs, code, strategy, and notebook, consistent with the competition organizer's current student-centered policies. Mentors may not substitute their work for student achievements or guarantee a competitive result.

NSF supervises NSF mentors; the participating team's Primary Coach manages its student roster, registration, adult supervision, parent permissions, conduct, and competition decisions. Adult contacts coordinate scheduling. A student's parent remains responsible for the child outside any expressly accepted NSF activity responsibilities.

4 Scheduling, location, and cancellation

Session frequency, duration, and location are confirmed in each Initial Mentorship Plan. Sessions may occur at an NSF-approved practice location, the participating team's usual location, or a mutually agreed virtual format, subject to available supervision and facilities. If a session conflicts with a competition or other operational, safety, or scheduling constraint, the adult leads seek a mutually agreed replacement date. An unconfirmed replacement date is not a scheduled commitment.

5 Youth safety, communications, and media

Each in-person session requires the responsible adults identified in the plan, age-appropriate supervision, and compliance with applicable safeguarding and venue rules. Adult mentors shall not privately message minor students outside approved communication channels. Urgent safety concerns and legally required reports must be handled without waiting for a routine program review. NSF may limit or postpone activities if adequate supervision or safety arrangements are unavailable.

Photos, video, identifiable voice, student names, or other public media use require appropriate separate written permission; consent is optional and does not determine participation eligibility. Completed media forms are stored securely, not published online. Approval for one organization's use does not automatically authorize an unrelated third party to reuse the media.

6 Property, funds, and organizational status

Mentorship alone does not create an NSF-operated team or make families corporate members, directors, or officers. Equipment loans, grants, reimbursements, monetary assistance, sponsorship arrangements, and affiliation changes require separate documented authorizations. The participating team may not use NSF's EIN, donor acknowledgment, or branding to solicit or hold money without express authorization. Any proposed charges, if permitted, must be separately approved and disclosed before commitment; the intake and plan themselves establish no fee.

7 Records, progress review, and concerns

NSF keeps session records describing date, general participant count, concepts taught, agreed student-created work, and next actions. After approximately three sessions, and at the term end, adult leads review progress in students' independent learning and decide whether to continue, modify, pause, or end support. Either side may request a pause or end. A request for continuation is subject to capacity and new agreement.

Program concerns may be submitted through the designated NSF adult contact or another authorized Foundation channel. Good-faith concerns, safety reporting, and lawful external reports are not restricted by this plan. Records are handled according to applicable privacy, retention, and lawful-access requirements.

8 Implementation and document control

Required package: (1) Team Mentorship Intake Form; (2) approved and confirmed Initial Mentorship Plan; (3) optional separate media permission for each identifiable minor; and (4) session/progress log. Board-controlled administrative records include the internal approval decision, adult contacts, relevant supervision confirmations, and any separately authorized financial or equipment arrangements.

Program administration. An authorized NSF Program Lead manages intake and mentorship plan approvals, coordinates applicable supervision, safeguarding, and venue review, and maintains program records. The Foundation maintains a separate record of document versions, approval authority, and effective dates.